Ying Xu

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Academic Position

Postdoctoral Scholar, The Kenneth C. Griffin Department of Economics,
The University of Chicago 2024-2027

Education

Columbia University
Ph.D., Economics and Education 2024
M.Phil, Economics and Education 2023

Peking University
MA, Economics and Education 2018

Beijing Normal University
BA, Public Affairs Administration 2015

Manchester University 2013
Exchange Student

Research Fields:

Primary fields: Economics and Education, Industrial Organization, Public Policy Analysis
Secondary fields: Labor Economics, Applied Microeconomics, Public Economics

Job Market Paper

Navigating Competitive Pressures: School Responses to Competition and the Distributional Effects on Student Achievement

Abstract: This paper examines the equity-efficiency implications of traditional public schools' (TPSs) responses to increased competition from charter schools. Using administrative data from North Carolina, I find that TPSs respond to student and teacher attrition to charter schools by reducing the number of classes, resulting in increased class sizes and higher student-teacher ratios. To maintain school proficiency rates, TPSs strategically reassign high-quality teachers to low-achieving and economically disadvantaged students. These effects remain consistent even after accounting for changes in school composition. Furthermore, I develop and estimate an empirical model of school choice and competition to analyze the impact of charter sector expansion. The findings indicate that expanding charter schools promotes a more

equitable distribution of high-quality teachers within TPSs. Additionally, optimizing teacher-student matching emerges as an effective strategy to improve allocative efficiency.

Working Papers

1.Wildfire Exposure and Learning Loss: Evidence from California. With Yifeng Luo. *Funded by the Russell Sage Foundation and William T. Grant Foundation for Improving Education Equality.*

Abstract: Wildfires have grown larger, more frequent, and more geographically widespread in the past decade, disrupting schooling and student learning. This paper links California student assessment data to detailed information on wildfires, school closures, wildfire smoke, and weather conditions to examine the causal effects of wildfire exposure on student academic achievement and the mechanisms through which these effects operate. Leveraging exogenous variation in wildfire shocks across time, geography, and intensity across schools and cohorts, we find that exposure to wildfires decreases Math and ELA scores by about 0.028 and 0.020 standard deviations, with larger effects among students with lower socioeconomic backgrounds. We also exploit quasi-random variation in wind direction and wildfire characteristics as instruments for school closures and smoke exposure to explore potential mechanisms. Our estimates identify both wildfire-induced school closures and smoke-related air pollution as important mechanisms: benchmark calculations suggest that closures account for roughly 15–20% of the observed learning losses, while smoke exposure accounts for an additional 33% of the decline in math achievement and 5\% of the decline in ELA achievement.

2. The Dignity of Work. With Manasi Deshpande and Rebecca Dizon-Ross.

Abstract: Work provides more than income: it may also offer meaning, structure, identity, and social interaction. Whether these nonfinancial benefits can be sustained outside paid employment has important implications for individual well-being and the design of public policy, particularly as advances in artificial intelligence reshape labor markets. This paper examines individuals' willingness to pay for work opportunities and nonfinancial job attributes, including meaningful activities, structured routines, and social interaction. We further estimate how government transfers affect these valuations and examine the causal effects of participation in work-like activities on individual well-being. Focusing on U.S. veterans, we exploit quasi-random assignment of disability claims to examiners with different propensities to award Veterans Disability Compensation (VDC). This examiner-based research design allows us to identify the causal effects of disability benefits on individuals' willingness to pay for work opportunities and their nonfinancial attributes. Understanding the nonpecuniary value of work and whether alternative activities can provide similar benefits has important implications for the design of social insurance and labor market policies in response to AI-driven labor market disruption.

3. Enrollment Hassles and the Targeting of Social Programs. With Manasi Deshpande and Charlie Rafkin.

Abstract: What are the impacts of enrollment hassles, or “ordeals,” on the take-up and targeting of transfer programs? A large literature studies this question, but it is hard to interpret because the research examines different settings and measures of need. We perform a meta-analysis of 130 studies and 570 targeting estimates, converting each study's estimates into a common measure of targeting: the gap in expected consumption between marginal enrollees and existing enrollees. On average, ordeals reduce take-up but have zero targeting effects. Targeting does not vary predictably with the program's baseline hassle level, recipients' average need, the type of hassle, or other study characteristics. We develop a framework to study the normative properties of ordeals in terms of gains to marginal and inframarginal enrollees. When calibrated using the meta-analysis, the welfare benefits of ordeals in terms of targeting

are typically small in magnitude. Because ordeals also impose deadweight loss on enrollees, reducing them would likely raise welfare.

4. Access Disruptions and the Consequences of Delayed Care: Evidence from Eye Injuries in India. With Manasi Deshpande, Kamalini Ramdas, Sanjay Jain, Josephine Christy, and Rengaraj Venkatesh.

Abstract: How does delayed access to specialized care affect recovery after an acute injury? This study examines the consequences of delays in reaching an eye hospital after an eye injury in India. Using patient-level data from multiple eye hospitals, we study how the time from injury to the first visit to a participating hospital affects the severity of the eye condition at presentation and longer-term health and social outcomes. To estimate the causal effects of delay, we exploit plausibly exogenous variation in the timing of hospital visits associated with adverse weather, local holidays, and elections in the days immediately following injury. We link patient records to detailed weather data along the route from each patient's village to the hospital they visited and to local holiday and election calendars. The study examines whether short-run disruptions in access to specialized care have consequences that persist beyond the initial episode of treatment.

5. Incentives to Finance: How Governments Affect the Tuition-Free Policy in Vocational Schools in China. With Zhilei Tian. *Research findings have been utilized by the State Council of China to refine the implementation of the tuition-free policy.*

Abstract: This paper assesses how government subsidies, aimed at reducing schooling costs to increase enrollment, interact with the supply-side fiscal burden. Policies like school fee waivers may heighten fiscal pressure on governments and potentially dampen their motivation to fund education, especially if such policies are imposed by higher-level authorities rather than being self-initiated. We analyze the impact of fiscal burdens from tuition-free policies on enrollment in China's secondary vocational schools. Through a geographic regression discontinuity design exploiting variation in fiscal responsibilities across county borders, we find a 21% enrollment decrease in these schools, with variations ranging from 14% to 40%. We also find that larger fiscal responsibilities borne by local governments lead to greater enrollment reductions.

6. Employment Protection, Teacher Hiring, and Teacher Productivity.

Abstract: This paper addresses the longstanding debate on employment protection's impact on productivity in the fields of economics and public policy. Focusing on teacher employment protection, often linked to unsatisfying school performance due to perceived weak incentives, this study seeks to provide empirical evidence on the topic. Utilizing policy changes in North Carolina that first eliminated and then reinstated teacher tenure, I investigate how removing employment protection influences teacher hiring practices in public schools, including changes in teacher characteristics and investment in professional development. Additionally, the study assesses the consequent effects on teacher productivity, evaluated using value-added models. Utilizing the comprehensive data available in North Carolina, I plan to develop and estimate an empirical model of the teacher labor market. This model will characterize 1) teachers' preferences regarding employment protection during job searches, and 2) the strategies of school districts in offering tenure as a means to compete for teachers and enhance school quality. The model will be employed to analyze the implications of various teacher tenure policy designs.

7. Peer Effects in Pro-environmental Behavior. With Yifeng Luo.

Abstract: This paper estimates the peer effects on pro-environmental behavior among college students. Our research demonstrates the influence of college peers on a student's pro-environmental actions. We use

a unique dataset that includes information on student pro-environmental behavior and their social networks from a Chinese university that randomly assigns students to dormitory rooms. Our findings reveal that students' willingness to pay for environmentally friendly initiatives and their recycling habits positively influence their peers' similar behaviors. These results are significant for policy-making, particularly in shaping sustainable development education strategies and assessing the effectiveness of educational policies aimed at promoting pro-environmental knowledge and actions.

8. Winners and Losers: The Distributional Effects of Transportation on College Monopsony Power.

Abstract: This paper explores how transportation infrastructure, specifically the extensive high-speed railway network in China, influences higher education markets. By leveraging this large-scale infrastructure project, this paper aims to understand the effects of transportation on colleges' market power in terms of their ability to attract high-aptitude students, both locally and from distant areas, and the variation of these effects depending on a college's geographical location and academic ranking.

Research Grants

2020-2022	**Russell Sage Foundation and William T. Grant Foundation for Improving Education Equality, Co-PI ($13,740)**
2022	Dean's Grant for Student Research at Teachers College (Top Two Finalist)

Awards and Fellowships

2024	Research Dissertation Fellowship, Teachers College (Awarded to top 2% of applicants for excellent dissertation research)
2020,2023	Arvid J and Mary Burke Scholarship, Teachers College
2023	Education Policy Dissertation Fellowship, Teachers College (Awarded to 6 applicants for excellent research in education policy)
2023	EPSA Research Travel Award, Teachers College
2023	The Provost's Grant for Conference Presentation, Teachers College
2022	Dean's Grant for Student Research at Teachers College (Top Two Finalist)
2018-2021	EPSA Departmental Doctoral Fellowship, Columbia University
2018	Honored Graduates, Outstanding Thesis Award, Peking University.
2017	National Scholarship, Central Government of China.
2016	Founder Scholarship, First-class Academic Fellowship, Merit Student, Peking University
2015	Honored Graduates**,** Beijing Municipal Education Commission and Beijing Normal University
2012-2014	First-class Academic Fellowship, Beijing Normal University
2014	Academic Competitiveness Awards, Beijing Normal University
2012	Merit Student, Beijing Normal University

Publications

Yang, Po, & Xu, Ying. (2017). Digital Divide and Inequality in Household Education Investment. *Peking University Education Review*, *15*(4), 126-154. (In Chinese)

Yang, Po, & Xu, Ying. (2020). Information Capital and Household Education Choice: Evidence from China. *Journal of East China Normal University Education Science*, *38*(11), 39-55. (In Chinese)

Gao, Wenjuan, & Xu, Ying. (2022). Empirical Research on Publication Output of American Doctoral Students During Their Studies: Taking 19 Economics Schools of Research Universities as Examples. *China Higher Education Research*, *(9):*102-108. (In Chinese)

Lian, J., & Xu, Y. (2016). New features in graduate education at the University of Toronto. In Ma, J., & Chen, Y. (Eds), *Development of graduate education of the world-class universities in 21st century:its new features and new trends* (pp. 104-139). Higher Education Press. (In Chinese)

Conference Presentations

2026	Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China
2025	SOLE Annual Meetings
2023	APPAM, AEFP, Columbia University Industrial Organization Colloquium
2022	RSF and William T. Grant Foundation: Improving Education and Reducing Inequality Conference, APPAM, AEA-CSWEP Mentoring Workshop for 3rd + Year Women & Non-Binary PhD Students, Econ & Ed Ph.D Students' Colloquium, Columbia University Industrial Organization Colloquium
2021	Econ & Ed Ph.D Students' Colloquium, Teachers College
2018	AEFP
2017	CIES, International Association for Feminist Economics Annual Conference, Academic Conference of Education Finance in China
2016	Summer School on Education Research (National Research University in Russia and China Institute for Education Finance Research)

Other Research Experience

2025-2026	World Bank Short-Term Consultant
2017-2019	National Assessment of Education Quality in China (*Funded by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Education of China),* Student Researcher
2015-2016	The Integration of ICT into Education in China (*Funded by the Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Education of China),* Student Researcher
2014-2015	The Development of Graduate Education in High-level Universities in the World **(***Funded by Chinese Society of Academic Degrees and Graduate Education***),** Student Researcher

Teaching Experience

Spring 2024	TA, Resource Allocation in Education, Teachers College
Fall 2023	TA, Statistics for Economics, Barnard College
2021-2023	TA, Data Analysis for Policy and Decision Making II, Teachers College
Summer 2023	TA and Course Developer, Behavior Economics with Applications to Education, Teachers College
Fall 2022	TA, Economics and Education, Barnard College
Fall 2017	TA, Advanced Quantitative Methods, Peking University
Spring 2017	TA, Education Statistics and Econometrics, Peking University

Professional Service

Senior Student Advisor for MA Students in Economics and Education, Teachers College

Miscellaneous

Programming: Tableau, SPSS, Stata, Python, Julia, R, HLM, ArcGIS, LaTeX
Language: Chines (Native), English (Professional)